

Under Mariwala, Marico—maker of Parachute coconut hair oil, Saffola cooking oil, male grooming brand Set Wet and Livon, a range of haircare products for women—has become a name to reckon with in the Fast Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) industry. It had sales of ₹9,653 crore and a net profit of ₹1,502 crore in financial year 2024. It had a market value of ₹78,537 crore at the stock's closing price of ₹606 on March 13.

The company has a presence in “over 25 countries across emerging markets of Asia and Africa” and “touches the lives of one out of every three Indians, through its portfolio of brands,” says the company’s website.

Now 73 years old, Mariwala quietly jots down a few points before reminiscing about his career, years in Bombay Oil and the launch and growth of Marico.

In many ways, the man is an oddity. For one thing, Mariwala does not have an MBA degree, a fact he says makes him more open-minded and willing to learn on the job. He consciously hires people he reckons are smarter than himself and ensures everyone puts the interests of the company first.

Mariwala’s professional journey has taught him a few lessons, perhaps the most important of which is a bottom-up approach—a business model in which plans are developed at lower levels of the organisation and funneled up until they reach the top management tier.

THE EARLY DAYS

Mariwala’s professional journey started in Masjid Bunder, a crowded wholesale market area in Mumbai where the family ran its commodity business.

“My father and uncle managed it and I was the first from the next generation. There was nobody to train me and I was asked to travel to meet customers,” Mariwala says.

Starting in 1948, the family had made and sold edible oils, oleo chemicals and spice extracts. It was when he started working in Bombay Oil and meeting customers that he saw a mar-

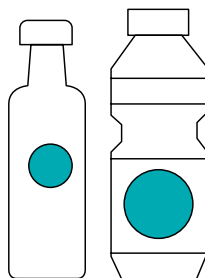
THE BEGINNING

01 **Mariwala came from the quintessential Indian family business background, where commodities was the primary venture**

02 **As a young man, he saw a clear opportunity in branded consumer products for both coconut oil and refined sunflower oil**

03 **Mariwala broke away to set up Marico Limited and created brands such as Parachute and Saffola**

04 **Marico went public in 1996, and in a few years staged off a potential takeover by HUL**



ket for oil products if sold in smaller branded forms.

This conversation took place in his corner office on the eighth floor of Grande Palladium in Kalina, a western Mumbai suburb. His office is lined with books, a testament to an ever-curious mind. He is reading a book these days on Tesla Inc. boss Elon Musk, who is very much in the news as a close associate of US President Donald Trump.

Mariwala downplays the importance of money as a motivator for his consumer business, but make no mistake, he is very passionate about Marico.

“The whole journey is not just about the money. The pride of owning an Indian company was far more important to me,” he says.

When an aggressive Hindustan Unilever Ltd, the Indian arm of Anglo-Dutch giant Unilever Plc., wanted to acquire Marico in the late 1990s, Mariwala’s steely resolve to keep ownership of the company showed itself.

In time, it was to lead to a delicious irony. More on that intriguing story a little later. He saw potential in selling branded consumer products—specifically coconut oil and refined sunflower oil—and through sheer perseverance, Mariwala built them into valuable businesses.

‘TIMELESS BRANDS’

Innovation excites him. In the case of Parachute coconut oil, it came in the most serendipitous manner when the product had its own distribution network and was sitting pretty with a 15% market share.

“We wanted to do something discontinuous and saw an opportunity in plastics when the product was being sold in tins,” Mariwala recalls. “The trade was resistant, and it took us five years to drive home the advantages of convenience, looks and a more affordable product.”

The effort paid off and from a 15% market share, Parachute moved remarkably to 50%—that was during the